

Chapter 114-3

Qiu Zimin had absolutely no idea why things had turned out this way.

After thinking it over and over, only Liang Shi could have done something like this.

Because she had treated Liang Shi poorly, Liang Shi was now taking crazy revenge on her, using her sons' kindness to stab her in the back.

She was really playing palace intrigue^{^1} masterfully.

No wonder she barely spoke to Liang Xinzhou before, yet took a knife for him just a few days ago.

It was all premeditated!

The more Qiu Zimin thought about it, the more plausible this seemed, and the more she resented Liang Shi.

Looking at her two sons, she found them less and less pleasing to the eye. She asked them directly, "Did Liang Shi instigate you to come here? Let me tell you, if you want Liang Shi to be part of this family, there's no way. She's not my daughter. I, Qiu Zimin, don't have such an unfilial daughter! Don't even think about it. Are you really going to drive me to death for someone with no blood relation?!"

"Get this straight!" Qiu Zimin said earnestly. "Xinran is your real sister. She was lost and wandering outside since childhood, suffering so much. Your father and I just want to compensate her a little more—what's wrong with that? Is her return getting in anyone's way? Every single one of you dislikes her!"

"I didn't come today to talk about this," Liang Xinzhou said coldly. "I came about Ling Dang. That day at the supermarket, Ling Dang said she didn't push anyone. Why did you take it upon yourselves to apologize on her behalf?"

Qiu Zimin paused.

What she was most displeased with first was Liang Xinzhou's tone. "Liang Xinzhou, I'm still your mother after all. Is this how you talk to me?!"

"On this matter, we're handling it officially," Liang Xinzhou said. "After we finish discussing this, we can talk about other issues."

Liang Xinzhou's tone was cold enough to genuinely hurt Qiu Zimin.

She had always thought Liang Xinzhou was the most outstanding among her children, but in the end...

It was all Liang Shi's fault!

Unable to hold up mentally, Qiu Zimin leaned against the sofa and said to him, "What do you want to say?"

Liang Xinhe looked at Qiu Zimin's sickly appearance and quietly tugged at Liang Xinzhou's clothes, whispering to him, "Take it easy."

Liang Xinzhou shot him a sidelong glance.

Liang Xinhe was immediately scared into silence.

Liang Xinzhou paused, then said in a deep voice, "When Ling Dang said she didn't do it, why wasn't your first reaction to verify? Instead, you decided she did it and took it upon yourselves to apologize on her behalf?"

He started with an interrogation.

Qiu Zimin shot back, "She's just a child. Does her saying she didn't do it mean she didn't do it? The surveillance cameras captured it. What? Do we have to wait until she gets taken to court before apologizing?"

"Ling Dang grew up under your watch. Don't you know whether she would lie or not?" Liang Xinzhou countered. "What kind of child she is—don't you have any idea? Are we afraid of being sued? Dongheng has so many lawyers on retainer. Worst case, your daughter-in-law graduated from a prestigious law school. Are you saying we can't afford to hire a lawyer to fight a lawsuit for Ling Dang?"

"It's not impossible for a child to lie in a moment of panic," Qiu Zimin said. "She's only five years old. What does she know? She'll forget about it in two days."

"How could that be?" Liang Xinhe couldn't help but speak up. "Ling Dang cried for a day and a night over this. And why did you scold Meirou? She hasn't gone to work so she can properly accompany Ling Dang, and you still say she hasn't raised Ling Dang well. Isn't that stabbing her in the heart?"

"Did I stop her from going to work?" Qiu Zimin asked dismissively, shooting a sidelong glance at her second son, who was always a fence-sitter². "Liang Xinhe, so you came today to stand up for your wife and child? I guess this mother is useless now, right? Don't forget, it was you who wanted her to stay home and be a full-time housewife."

"I asked her to be a full-time housewife, but I never said she wasn't raising Ling Dang well," Liang Xinhe said. "My Ling Dang is well-behaved, obedient, cute, and kind. If she says she didn't do it, then she didn't do it. You wrongly accused her without distinguishing right from wrong. The damage this caused to her young heart is too great."

The two brothers were both used to the ways of the business world and didn't know how to speak softly at home.

They took turns lecturing Qiu Zimin.

Looking at them, Qiu Zimin felt more and more heartbroken.

She truly couldn't understand how her excellent sons, whom she had raised for so many years, had turned out like this.

Just as they were taking turns trying to reason with Qiu Zimin, she lay on the sofa, nearly unable to catch her breath.

Liang Xinran, who was standing to the side, immediately helped her calm her breathing. She also said to Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe, "Big Brother, Second Brother, I'm sorry. I was the one who took Ling Dang out that day. I didn't expect her to do something like that. I'm nearsighted and couldn't see clearly, but Ling Dang did reach out her hand. No one expected that child to have an illness. I'm really sorry. I won't do this again. Please don't... don't take this up with Mom anymore. Come to me instead. I'll go apologize to Ling Dang."

With that innocent face of hers, her eyes reddened as soon as she spoke, her voice choked with emotion, making anyone who saw her feel pity.

Hearing her say this, Qiu Zimin felt unbearable heartache and immediately grabbed her hand. "Xinran, this isn't your fault. You don't need to do this."

"Every single one of these people has been led astray by that Liang Shi until they're blind in eyes and heart, unable to recognize who their real family is!" After comforting Liang Xinran, Qiu Zimin angrily said to the two of them, "Have you gone mad? When did I ever teach you to point knives at your own family? Can't you use your brains?"

Qiu Zimin said, "Xinran took Ling Dang out with good intentions. When she saw Ling Dang did something wrong, she desperately apologized to the other party, afraid that the other child's parents would do something to Ling Dang. All of you feel sorry for Ling Dang, but does anyone feel sorry for Xinran?"

Liang Xinhe let out a light scoff. "Don't you feel sorry for her?"

Qiu Zimin was momentarily speechless.

Footnotes:

^{^1} Palace intrigue (宮心計, gōng xīn jì): Refers to the scheming and manipulation commonly depicted in Chinese palace dramas, where concubines and court members plot against each other for power and favor. It's used here to describe Liang Shi as being manipulative and calculating.

^{^2} Fence-sitter (牆頭草, qiáng tóu cǎo): Literally "grass on top of a wall," this Chinese idiom describes someone who sways with the wind and doesn't take a firm stance, always going along with whoever seems to have the upper hand.